

First-Time Experiences That Have Shaped Us

Every adult I have ever interviewed remembers at least one first-time experience that has changed them irreversibly. Some are obvious — the first day at university, the first job, the first time leaving the country. Others are more counterintuitive — a peculiar conversation with a stranger that has stayed with them for decades, or an uncomfortable silence at a dinner that taught them more than any lecture.

I have collected stories from over a hundred people, and the empirical pattern is irrefutable: the experiences that have shaped us most are rarely the ones we planned. They are asymmetric — small in the moment, indispensable in retrospect.

Maria has told me she still remembers the first time she gave a presentation in English to a foreign client. She was 24. She had never spoken to a foreigner alone before, and she felt utterly vulnerable. The presentation itself was mediocre — she has admitted that herself. But the experience compelled her to enroll in an English program, and now, eight years later, she negotiates international contracts every week.

Carlos, who I have known since university, shared something different. He had always been confident, but a single feedback session with a senior mentor in 2018 changed his trajectory. The mentor said, "Your work is good, but it incentivizes the wrong behavior in your team." It was compelling — and uncomfortable. Carlos has rebuilt his leadership style since then. He says that conversation has been more useful than any course he has taken.

The lesson is simple, even if it sounds counterintuitive: you don't need to plan transformative experiences. You need to be open to them when they arrive. Some will feel peculiar at first, others uncomfortable. Many will leave you vulnerable. But these are precisely the moments that, looking back, you'll realize have shaped who you have become.